is what a yatra teaches. With each step, one foot is in the past and the other strides towards the future.

Though I have had many experiences of yatras, here is an attempt to present the moments spent during the Bharat Jodo Yatra in Madhya Pradesh. Like the beautiful lines of Bhawani Prasad Mishra's poetry, the Yatra passed through the Satpura's sprawling, untamed green forests and reached Burhanpur. This is the southern gateway to Madhya Pradesh, showcasing its role in the central region due to its geographical and cultural diversity. Burhanpur is a historically significant city that safeguarded northern India's political power from the political turmoil in the Deccan. It is also where Mumtaz Mahal breathed her last. Burhanpur is famous for its Ganga–Jamuni culture.

As the journey progressed through the rural areas of Burhanpur, encounters with fields and hard-working female and male farmers became more frequent. Burhanpur excels in banana production, and the shade of the southern fields is seen here. It's hard to believe that we are thousands of kilometres away in Madhya Pradesh, not in Kerala. On one side, there are banana plantations and on the other are fields of fluffy white cotton.

Burhanpur is home to a power loom operated by the Muslim community. Women, men and young people from the family run the loom throughout the day. In the afternoon break of the first day of the Yatra, a delegation of banana-producing farmers and power-loom operators joined the journey. The journey was a daily affair. While the other full-time or regional yatris relaxed and chatted during the rest of the day, Rahul ji met the local people from specific sectors—especially those whose voices are not heard in the corridors of power. If a city or a district has particular features or occupations, the associated communities are approached for discussion. There is an eagerness to learn from them, express curiosity and exchange ideas. Often, it is observed that politicians, in their desire to know everything, become oblivious. Witnessing a humble leader, eager to learn and far from such arrogance, was a gratifying experience.

The banana-producing farmers shared their difficulties. They explained how they did not benefit from the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana